



Microsoft Office on iPhone

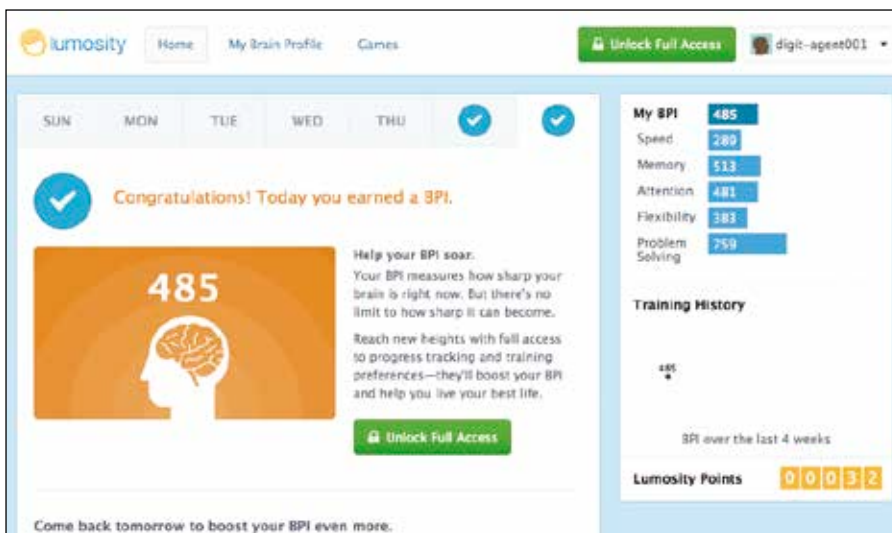
Microsoft rolled out Office app for iPhone - requires Office 365 subscription and no iPad version



Internet from Balloons

Google is working on 'Project Loon' - a project to provide internet for everyone across the world using Balloons

Feature



After a day of training on Lumosity

when you register for the program you are greeted with a wizard which helps you build your personalized training program. The areas where Lumosity focuses are memory, attention, speed, flexibility and training. Lumosity offers different games to improve specific aspects in these areas viz., for memory, the aspects on which training is offered are recalling the location of objects, remembering names after the first introduction, learning new subjects quickly and accurately and keeping track of several ideas at the same time. I wanted to check all the tests that they had to offer thus I selected every aspect of focus areas on offer for my personal training.

The games themselves are incredibly polished and well designed. I played 'Speed Match', which improves my speed and memory. I played 'Eagle Eye' and 'Lost in Migration' which worked on my



Speed Match is good to sharpen the brain

attention skills. I played 'Speed Match' and 'Memory Map' enhancing my short-term memory and 'Word Bubbles' and 'Rain Drops' for flexibility and problem solving skills respectively. In the free version you can play these games only once per day. The games are not accessible after you've completed your daily dose of brain boosters. Another thing to note is that these games are assigned to you on a random basis, thus everyday is like a lottery. Lumosity's own scoring index is called BPI (Brain Power Index), which it derives by comparing your game scores with results from other players, and assigning you an index based on your relative performance.

Now talking about the results, I tried to stick to the regime that I came up with, but quite frankly I was not able to do it everyday. I stuck to the schedule for the

first two weeks but then the practice session kept on becoming more sporadic. I found the games slightly juvenile - stars dancing around the screen, submarines, monsters and penguins, which made it quite boring to trudge through the games everyday. Though this is what I felt, and other people who are playing these games might not necessarily feel the same. I took the final Cambridge Brain Sciences test at the same time and same conditions as the first one, so there is no discrepancy in the result. I scored in the 38th percentile in short-term memory, 78th percentile in reasoning ability and 49th percentile in verbal ability, a modicum of progress in all areas. According to Lumosity itself I have been able to bump my BPI from 485 to 672 in the span of one month, with the largest gains in memory, speed and problem solving. The free version does not let you see your historical performance and the detailed breakdown of your performance, but if you keep the track of your scores then you can make out your strengths and weaknesses easily enough.

The most important question, is it actually effective? I am now supposedly more intelligent than I started out, but the skeptic in me refuses to believe. Does intelligence in its truest sense only mean getting better in these sections? I couldn't actually see my performance on each and every game that I played but I could make out from the general progress in scores that the more I played a particular game, the more I scored.

I played these games repeatedly for quite some time and the final test panned out in the same vein, and thus I believe that I've gotten better only at these particular games and tests. Nonetheless, it does feel like I have achieved something even if it's a few notches higher in the BPI or hitting a higher percentile on the tests. Not necessarily boosting your IQ and making you a genius, these games in my opinion are just a form of mental exercise. They just keep your brain in shape like any other muscle in the body, the choice of training is entirely your. It can be Sudoku or a crossword in your daily paper, riddles and puzzle, math-based exercises or even brain games such as these. 

ALTERNATIVE BRAIN TRAINING PROGRAMS/GAMES

Brain Spade Games
www.brainspade.com
 AARP Brain Games
games.aarp.org
 Brain Metrix
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 Brain Age Games
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